

est scanner we received for this comparison test. The 5550c was also best suited for the purpose of OCR. The ADF attachment of this scanner can take 35 sheets at a time and in our OCR test, ABBYY FineReader 6.0CE recognised only one character incorrectly. This makes it best suited for batch processing, where converting print information into a digital format is a very important and painstaking task.

The Microtek ScanMaker X12UL, which returned equally impressive image quality, lost to HP in the speed test. This was the only scanner in our comparison test to have both, a SCSI and a USB interface. Those who still have older SCSI scanners which need to be replaced should give this one a look. The price of the scanner is Rs 15,990 which includes the SCSI card and a cable, making it an affordable solution.

The HP 5550C, which very much deserved the crown based on the quality that it delivered, lost to its own sibling, the HP Scanjet 4570c. The 5550c scored 80.40 STTI as compared to the 84.22 scored by 4570c. This was primarily because the 5550c is priced Rs 7,000 higher. The 4570c delivers good quality scans at a faster rate and is also sturdily built. This scanner also has an option for Automatic Photo Feeder and Transparency Material Adapter, which extends its usability.

**We recommend the HP Scanjet 4570. This scanner delivers astounding quality at the right price.**

**What it all leads to...**

Benq which was also an eager participant with three models that yielded below average performances. The S2W 7400UT, in particular, gave dark scans of images, and features such as a Transparency Adapter and a compact design were absent.

Products from HP came on top in two out of the three segments. Only the business category was taken over by UMAX Astra, because of its fast speed and brilliant quality. The Astra 2500 is a very average looking scanner that is pretty low on the features but quite adept at performing the basic job.

HP Scanjet 5500c, on the other hand is one of the most feature rich scanners. In fact, at first glance, it does not look like a scanner—with an ADF for a cover, nine buttons and an LCD display, this scanner is made for the future.

Epson decided to pull out of the scanner segment, and the quality delivered by them was sorely missed.

**Best performance**

If quality is paramount to you, then the HP 4570c will meet your requirement. With a resolution of 2400 dpi and a 48-bit colour depth, this sleek-looking scanner brings eye-pleasing images to you monitor. It also has a connector for the Transparency Adapter, which makes it multifaceted and extends its usability to more media type. The scanner has a USB interface, which means that getting it up and running is a piece of cake. The quality delivered, and the features that it offers, is



*HP Scanjet 4570c*  
*The aerodynamic looks and impressive looks, make it a perfect companion for most scanning tasks*

further backed by the results of the speed test—a testament to its efficiency. Although the Rs 17,999 price tag takes it out of the reach of most home users, the features this scanner offers—scan to CD, print and e-mail along with a dedicated key to select colour and line art mode—makes it very easy to use. The build quality and aesthetics are excellent, making it a perfect tool for those who can afford it.

**Best value**

The UMAX Astra 2500 has proved to be a workhorse—fast, efficient and simple—these are the keywords to describe it. The best thing about this scanner is that if used continuously, the 2500



*Umax Astra 2500*  
*This scanner is a perfect blend of price and performance*

will scan each document faster than the previous one. The design is very simple, with no rounded corners, giving it an aged look. The same old beige colour further reinforces this appearance. Looks aside, this scanner costs only Rs 3,950, making it a very affordable and a no-nonsense solution for simple day-to-day scanning. This was also one of the few scanners missing hot keys, a popular feature with a majority of today's scanners.

While low on features, the Astra 2500 delivers on quality and is also good for OCR. The only bottleneck is the lack of connectivity for an ADF attachment. Its performance results and bundled goodies—which include image editing software, OCR software and so on—makes the investment more worthwhile.

ALIASGAR PARDAWALA AND AHMED SHAIKH

| Decision Maker      |                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                     | Home User                                                                                                       | Business User                                                                                                                                             | Professionals                                                                                                                              |
| You need            | To scan documents including combi-documents and occasionally images. Quality and feature are not very important | To scan documents printed on different media. Scans Images and even books at a decent resolution and needs accuracy as well as quality with some features | To scan negatives at a high resolution, and therefore needs a Transparency adapter. Scans images and also needs ADF for batch scan for OCR |
| Look for            | Scanner with a bit-depth of more than 24-bit and resolution of 600 dpi                                          | Scanner with at least three hot keys and resolution support of 1200 dpi at 48-bit colour depth                                                            | Scanner with built-in Transparency adapter or ADF as optional attachment with resolution of 2400 dpi at 48-bit                             |
| Our recommendations | HP Scanjet 2300c and Umax AstraSlim 600                                                                         | UMAX Astra 2500, HP scanjet 3500c                                                                                                                         | HP Scanjet 5550c, 4570c                                                                                                                    |
| Price Range         | Rs 3,400 to 4,000                                                                                               | Rs 4,000 to 10,000                                                                                                                                        | Rs 10,000 to 25,000                                                                                                                        |